

The Pass

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The pass had come in the middle of the week, which Briggs considered suspicious. The army barely gave passes at all, and when it did, there was invariably a reason that revealed itself later and was never pleasant. He took it anyway.

"You're coming with me," he told Blackhoof, in the tone he used for orders that were not quite orders.

"Where?"

"Somewhere with a roof and cards and something drinkable." He was already pulling on his coat. "You can wait outside if you want."

Blackhoof had not waited outside.

The dwarf settlement three miles east of camp had the quality of a place that had decided long ago not to bother with appearances. The buildings were low and solid and slightly underground, the way dwarves preferred, and the establishment Briggs led them to had no sign above the door — just a smell of woodsmoke and ale and the particular atmosphere of a room where money changed hands regularly and not always voluntarily.

Blackhoof had to fold himself considerably to get through the door.

Nobody looked up.

"They've seen centaurs before," Briggs said, reading his expression.

"I wasn't worried about that."

"You were a little worried about that."

He found them a table — large enough for Blackhoof to settle beside rather than at, which the establishment seemed to have anticipated — and flagged down something to drink and waited. He never sought out the game. The game always found him, eventually, drawn by some quality he had that Blackhoof had never quite identified. Within twenty minutes, three dwarves had pulled up chairs and a fourth was dealing.

Briggs picked up his cards.

His face did nothing whatsoever.

The thing about Briggs at cards, centaur had come to understand, was that it wasn't skill, exactly. Or rather, it wasn't only skill. There was something else operating — some alignment between the man and the mathematics of chance that functioned like a conversation Briggs was having with the universe in a language nobody else spoke. He didn't cheat. Blackhoof had watched him closely enough to be certain of that. He simply won, steadily and without drama, the way water found its way downhill.

The dwarves were good players. It didn't matter.

By the third hour, the pile in front of Briggs had grown to a size that had stopped being comfortable for everyone else at the table. The dwarf across from him — broad-faced, red-bearded, with the expression of a man revising his assumptions about the evening — had stopped speaking between hands. The other three had gone quiet in the particular way of men doing arithmetic and not enjoying the results.

Briggs won the next hand.

And the next.

"I think," said young one quietly, leaning down toward him, "that we should perhaps—"

"One more," said Briggs.

He lost on purpose, trying to ease the sour edge.

The night air was cold and clean after the fug of the bar, and Briggs was in the best mood Blackhoof had seen him in, which manifested as a slight reduction in his usual grimness and an almost imperceptible looseness in his stride. He was counting the winnings as they walked, with the focused satisfaction of a man communing with something he loved.

"You should put that away," Blackhoof said.

"In a moment."

"Serg!"

"Almost done."

They were halfway down the track back toward camp when the four of them stepped out of the treeline.

Red-beard. And three friends.

Blackhoof had time to note that they had thought to bring axe handles — not blades, which suggested they wanted the money back more than they wanted a murder charge — and then there was no more time for noting anything.

The problem with fighting four dwarves without weapons, Blackhoof reflected afterward, was that dwarves were built in a manner specifically optimised for not being moved. Low centre of gravity. Disproportionate upper body strength. The natural stubbornness of a species that had spent centuries arguing with mountains.

He got one of them down with a shoulder charge that he was fairly proud of, and took an axe handle across the ribs for it that drove the pride directly out of him. Briggs, operating at roughly chest height to everyone present, had apparently decided that the most effective strategy available was to become as difficult to hit as possible while hitting everything within reach, and was executing this with the grim efficiency of a man working through a to-do list. It wasn't enough. Handles were as hard as his skull. And the numbers weren't right.

Blackhoof hit the ground and stood up. Guarding the fallen gnome, giving his best to protect him. The second time was harder. The third time he got partway up and the ground seemed to make a compelling case for staying, and he found he didn't have a strong counter-argument.

Then boots on the track, retreating. The clink of a coin bag. Briggs's voice, close to the ground, saying something in a language centaur didn't recognise that was probably either a prayer or a profanity and was possibly both.

Then quiet.

The stars were very clear from down here.

Centaur lay on the track and breathed carefully, cataloguing the damage. Ribs — two or three, possibly. Left foreleg had been struck repeatedly and was making its feelings known. Something above his right eye was contributing warmly to his general situation.

Beside him, Briggs was also horizontal.

"Are you alive?"

"Provisionally," said Briggs.

A pause.

"They took the winnings," centaur said.

"Yes."

"All of it."

"I'm aware."

Another pause, longer.

"Was it worth it?" Blackhoof asked.

Briggs seemed to consider this seriously. "The playing was worth it," he said finally. "The walking home was perhaps misjudged."

Blackhoof made a sound that was intended to be a laugh and arrived as something more complicated. His ribs registered a formal complaint.

"Can you get up?" Briggs asked.

"Eventually. You?"

"Also eventually."

They lay there for a while, under the very clear stars, on the cold track, saying nothing. Somewhere in the trees an owl made its opinions known and was ignored.

Briggs moved first — the slow, deliberate movement of a man negotiating with his own body. He got to sitting, then to his feet, with the careful architecture of someone building something fragile. He stood for a moment, taking stock.

Then he reached down.

Blackhoof took the hand — small, practical, callused — and used it as an anchor while he got his legs sorted out beneath him, which took longer than he would have liked and involved more undignified scrambling than he intended to remember. Briggs held on without comment.

until the geometry resolved itself and Blackhoof was upright and they were standing on the track together in the dark, both somewhat the worse for the evening.

Something shifted in Briggs's expression. Not softness, exactly — the man didn't really do softness. But something that had been held at a certain careful distance for a long time moved, quietly, and didn't move back.

Too many, he had told himself, over and over, since the first campaign and the first loss and all the losses after. Don't. You know how it ends.

He looked at this ridiculous, idealistic, half-disillusioned, genuinely brave young centaur who had followed him into a dwarf bar without complaint and fought four opponents without weapons and had not, at any point, suggested that any of this was anything other than a reasonable way to spend an evening.

The arithmetic was what it was.

"Come on, Blacky," he said. "Let's go home."

It was the first time.

Blackhoof heard it. He said nothing for a moment, because the moment seemed to require a certain respect. Then, as they started down the track toward camp — slowly, and with the collaborative limping of two people sharing a problem with their combined structural integrity:

"You're buying the drinks next time, Biggs."

Gnome said nothing. But he didn't tell him not to.

